The Secret Garden

A simplified retelling

Original story by Frances Hodgson Burnett

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A lonely arrival

Mary Lennox had grown up in India with servants who did almost everything for her. Her parents paid her little attention, and she had learned to demand what she wanted without thinking about anyone else.

When a cholera outbreak killed her parents, Mary was sent to England. Her uncle, Archibald Craven, lived at Misselthwaite Manor in Yorkshire. She arrived at a huge house surrounded by open moorland.

Her uncle was often away. The housekeeper, Mrs Medlock, warned Mary not to wander through the rooms. Mary expected to dislike everything.

But her young maid, Martha, did not treat her like the servants in India. Martha expected her to dress herself. She also talked cheerfully about her own large family, especially her brother Dickon, who understood animals and loved being outdoors.

With little entertainment inside, Mary began walking in the grounds. The cold air gave her an appetite. For the first time, she became curious about something beyond her own comfort.

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2. The locked door

Martha told Mary about a garden that had been locked for ten years. It had belonged to Mrs Craven, who died after an accident there. In his grief, Mr Craven ordered the door shut and the key buried.

Mary wanted to find it.

She met the gardener, Ben Weatherstaff, and watched a robin that seemed less afraid of people than other birds. The robin led her attention towards a patch of disturbed earth. Mary found an old key.

Later, the wind moved some ivy against a wall, revealing a door. The key fitted. She stepped into the secret garden.

It looked tangled and neglected, but it was not dead. Mary could see small green shoots. She began clearing space around them, working carefully so she would not damage what was growing.

The garden became a secret that made her want to get up in the morning. She no longer had to wait for someone else to decide how to fill her day.

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3. A friend who knows growing things

Mary bought seeds and tools with Dickon’s help. When he came to see her, she found him surrounded by the easy trust of animals. She decided she could trust him too.

She showed him the hidden garden. He recognised living branches beneath the untidy growth and explained how to care for them. Together they planted, cleared and waited.

Mary had once disliked almost everyone. Now she had a friend, useful work and things she wanted to share. She was stronger from walking and working, and she began to notice other people’s feelings.

Mr Craven briefly returned. Mary asked for a little piece of earth to grow things in. He agreed without realising which garden she meant.

At night, however, she sometimes heard crying somewhere in the house. Mrs Medlock insisted that she had heard nothing she should concern herself with. Mary was not convinced.

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4. The boy behind the curtains

One night, Mary followed the sound and found a boy in a large bedroom. He was her cousin, Colin Craven.

Colin had been kept apart from ordinary life. He believed he was going to die young or develop a problem with his back like his father’s. Servants feared upsetting him, so they obeyed his demands and repeated their worries where he could hear them.

Mary did not respond as they did. When he became unreasonable, she argued with him. She told him about the outdoors, Dickon and growing things. He wanted to hear more.

Their friendship was not always gentle. They were both used to controlling a room through bad temper. But Mary’s certainty that he could have a different life began to challenge his certainty that everything was hopeless.

She decided that he should see the garden. Dickon agreed to help.

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5. Through the garden door

The children arranged to take Colin outside in a wheeled chair. The servants were told to keep away, and Dickon guided him into the secret garden.

Spring had transformed it. Birds moved among the branches, flowers were opening, and the air seemed full of activity. Colin looked around with amazement.

Ben Weatherstaff discovered them and spoke bluntly about Colin’s supposed weakness. Colin became angry enough to stand and show that his legs could support him. With help, he began taking steps.

They agreed to keep his progress secret from most of the household. Colin wanted to surprise his father. Ben, who had cared for some of the roses secretly for years, joined their work.

Colin called the life he felt around him “Magic.” The children used the word for the energy of growing things and for the new hope that helped him attempt more each day. Progress still required food, exercise, patience and support.

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6. The way home

Martha and Dickon’s mother, Susan Sowerby, helped the children and thought about Colin’s lonely father. She wrote to Mr Craven and encouraged him to return.

He had been travelling without finding much peace. Thoughts of his wife and a strange feeling of hope led him home. At Misselthwaite, he discovered that Colin was outside rather than shut in his room.

He went towards the garden he had avoided for ten years. Just as he reached the doorway, a boy ran out and nearly collided with him.

It was Colin, standing and moving freely.

Father and son entered the garden together. Colin explained the work, the friendships and the secret. The place Mr Craven associated only with loss had become part of his son’s life.

They walked back to the house side by side. Mary’s discovery had changed more than a neglected garden. It had opened a door between people who had been living apart, even under the same roof.

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Words to keep

Neglected — not receiving enough attention or care. The neglected garden was overgrown.

Moorland — open, uncultivated land with low plants. Mary walked near the Yorkshire moorland.

Shoot — a new part of a plant beginning to grow. Green shoots showed that the garden was alive.

Temper — a tendency to become angry. Both cousins had difficult tempers.

Support — help that makes something possible. Colin needed support while learning to walk outside.

Grief — deep sadness after a death. Mr Craven’s grief had kept him away.

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A question to carry with you

What changes when someone is encouraged to try a manageable action instead of being told only what they cannot do?

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